very few occasions when it doesn't matter how long you bat. I was 182 not out overnight and woke up with a single thought in my head: 'This is your chance to go massive.'

The pitch was flat. I had dispelled doubt, created by averaging only five in the series going into the game. The Indians, who had required late-innings defiance by MS Dhoni to reach 244, knew defeat was inevitable. It was Test cricket at its most brutal. It is rarely as obvious as football or rugby, where dominance is reflected by six-goal or sixty-point winning margins. Distress signals are subtle, but instantly recognizable at close quarters.

The Indian bowlers steamed in for the first hour, but I sensed a slight sag in the shoulders, a realization they each faced another thankless twenty-over shift across another long day. Their intensity level fell by a fateful fraction. My partnership of 222 with Eoin Morgan was cricket's equivalent of water torture. I scored only two boundaries in two sessions; a mid-afternoon power cut was the opposition's only release.

They spread the field in the hope of delaying the declaration, which we planned to make if I got 300. Runs came steadily through midwicket, or behind square on the off side. I was on 294 with the field spread, and everyone on the boundary, when I attempted to hit the ball too hard. I couldn't believe it when I top-edged a loose drive and was caught at deep backward point.

History turned to dust. At that moment it didn't matter that my innings of 294, which lasted seven minutes short of thirteen hours, was the highest in Edgbaston's 116-year Test history, and England's biggest since Graham Gooch's 333, twenty-one years earlier. As in my final Test innings, public acclaim couldn't deflect private reproach.

Perspective, of sorts, was quickly reasserted by the manifestation of my worst nightmare, a king pair in Test cricket. Virender Sehwag had nearly three full days to digest the consequences of gloving off Stuart Broad to Matty Prior in the first innings. He seemed almost beyond caring in the second. A massive drive at Jimmy Anderson's first delivery, an away-swinger, sped to Andrew Strauss at first slip.

Victory, and number one status, was confirmed the following day, when Kevin Pietersen caught Shanthakumaran Sreesanth in the gully, off Tim Bresnan. There's a lovely painting of our response, running to form a huddle with arms aloft. Though the consistency of the reaction is